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Abstract

A Lone Star's Loyalty: How the Texas Pledge Reflects State Identity and Traditionalistic Values

by

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Abstract

The purpose of this research was to explore how Texas's traditionalistic values have shaped public expressions of state identity, focusing on the Texas Pledge of Allegiance as a focal example from its inception in 1933 to 2024. The simple expression of state pride has evolved over the years, first with the removal of "1836" to accurately reflect the current flag adopted in 1839, and later with the addition of the words "under God" in 2007. These changes beg questions as to the factors that would have motivated such and how they aligned with the values in the political and cultural context of Texas. A qualitative case study approach was employed, examining legislative documents, historical records, news articles, and public commentary to highlight the influence of these values on policy. The findings reveal that Texas's commitment to traditionalism was reflected in both symbolic and practical governance. Future research should explore how such legislation impacted public perception and Texas's position within national political discourse.

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A Lone Star's Loyalty: How the Texas Pledge Reflects State Identity and Traditionalistic Values

“Honor the Texas flag; I Pledge allegiance to thee, Texas, one state under God, one and indivisible.” – Dr. B.R. Abernethy, June 15, 2007

Section 1. Problem Statement

The Texas Pledge of Allegiance (Hereinafter “Pledge”), which was first introduced in 1933, has undergone many changes since its inception. The simple expression of state pride has evolved over the years, notably with the removal of “1836” to accurately reflect the current flag adopted in 1839, and the addition of the phrase “under God” in 2007. These amendments raise questions about the factors motivating such changes and how they align with the cultural values in Texas.

The primary players for this research include politicians and religious groups. Texas Politicians have played a part in implementing amendments, often reflecting the state’s political views and values while religious groups like Christian nationalists have been influential in fighting for changes, such as the addition of “under God” to align with traditional values in Texas. The secondary players are the citizens and educators, who are responsible for the recitation of the Pledge in schools, impacting student’s environmental and educational experiences. Additionally, the Immigrants and Minority Groups play a crucial role, as their perceptions of the Pledge reflect how Texas’s evolving identity and political culture affect cultural integration and diversity.

The stakes of examining how the Texas Pledge evolution reflects the broader state political views are high. The inclusion of religious language, for example, raises questions about the balance between state identity and religious neutrality. Understanding the motivation behind these amendments can provide insight into the traditionalistic political culture of Texas,

characterized by the preservation of the status quo and a preference for limited government intervention. This cultural context significantly impacts legislation in our daily lives.

Therefore, why was the Texas Pledge altered twice? If the political culture of Texas operates in a traditionalistic way, then a correlation exists between the alterations and current Texas legislation. This study aims to uncover the key motivations behind these amendments, examining how changes in the Pledge reflect broader shifts in Texas's political and cultural landscape.

Section 2. Historical Background on the Texas Pledge

Before the Pledge was drafted, Texas existed under six national flags: Spain (1519-1685;1690-1821), France (1685-1690), Mexico (1821-1836), the Republic of Texas (1836-1845), the Confederate States of America (1861-1865), and eventually the United States of America (1845-present). Under European nations, Texas started as a colonial region that later gained independence being part of a sovereign country. Because of this, the Pledge became a way to celebrate its independence from Mexico in 1836 (Linden, 2023). In 1933, the Daughters of the American Revolution wrote the Pledge but it still referenced the "Texas Flag of 1836." So, lawmakers corrected the issue in 1965 by removing the 1836 reference to properly align more with its historical flag. Later in 2007, the phrase "Under God" was added to the Pledge by the Texas Legislature. This change was driven by the traditionalistic values of Texas and by the national trend of the same phrase being amended into the United States Pledge of Allegiance. Currently, the Texas Pledge is still very much known around the state and nation and is also recited in schools, football games, and public events within Texas.

There are a lot of reasons why the Texas Pledge was put in place. One was because Texas had a unique history of being an independent nation before joining the U.S. in 1845 (Linden,

2023). This period of independence has become a source of pride for many Texans, contributing to a strong sense of state identity. Beyond this, Texas's cultural heritage, influenced by its Spanish, Mexican, Native American, and Immigrant cultures, has fostered a distinct identity that the Pledge helps to express and reinforce. The Pledge is a powerful symbol of state pride, reminding Texans of the state's unique characteristics and values (Linden, 2023). Furthermore, it serves an educational purpose, helping to instill knowledge of Texas history and civics in students by promoting a deeper understanding of the state's government and cultural significance. Beyond education, the Pledge also functions as a symbol of unity among Texas's diverse population, emphasizing allegiance to the state and the shared identity of being "Texan" regardless of individual background (Linden, 2023). Over time, it has also taken on a political and social dimension, reflecting Texans' views on state sovereignty and the role of religion, particularly through the addition of "under God" in 2007. This reflects not only Texas's values but also how legislative changes align with the state's public sentiment and political priorities at different times (Linden, 2023).

Some of the key elements of the Texas Pledge demonstrate the cultural and political values that Texas stands for. It starts with honoring the state flag, reflecting the respect that people in Texas have for their state symbol. It shows how it also correlates with the act of allegiance to the United States. The phrase "*one state under God*" just like in the nation's Pledge, reveals how important religious values are in Texas' identity. Although it has sparked debates about the separation of church and state, as mandated by the Establishment Clause of the First Amendment, which prohibits the government from making any law "respecting an establishment of religion." Critics argue that such religious references in state pledges and public schools may violate this clause, blurring the line between church and state. However, supporters assert that it

reflects the historical and cultural heritage of the state and its traditionalistic political culture which often intertwines religious values with public life. And finally, the phrase “one and indivisible” emphasizes the state’s focus on maintaining a unified identity, regardless of its diverse population and evolving political landscape. This aspect reinforces Texas’s deep-seated belief in state loyalty and indivisibility, symbolizing the strength and cohesiveness of its identity (Linden, 2023).

Section 3. Current Research on the Political Culture in Texas from 2024

Between 2023 and 2024, The Texas Nationalist Movement (hereinafter “TNM”) played a key role in modern discussions surrounding Texas’s political culture. It reinforced its traditionalistic values and emphasized a historical desire for autonomy (Salinas, 2024). Despite limited support overall, the movement gained traction with its push for Texit. This push in momentum is important in understanding contemporary political dynamics, aligning with my research thesis that explores how political and cultural shifts in Texas impact its symbols, including the Texas Pledge.

The rise of the TNM can be compared to earlier amendments in the Texas Pledge, such as the addition of “under God” in 2007. Both reflect a reaction to perceived threats to Texas’s cultural and political identity, showcasing how state-specific values influence legislation and symbolic language. For instance, the strong emphasis on individualism and self-reliance is a core value deeply embedded in Texas's identity. This value is evident in Texas's historical commitment to limited government and personal freedom, which frequently influences state legislation and symbolic actions, like the Texas Pledge. The TNM, like the religious groups behind the 2007 amendment, is deeply rooted in traditionalist views, often advocating for

policies and changes that reinforce Texas's distinct identity and independence from federal control.

Analyzing the motivations behind Texit and the TNM's broader implications reveals a continuity in Texas's political culture—a tendency to resist national authority in favor of maintaining sovereignty. This perspective resonates with past amendments to the Texas Pledge, where changes were implemented as symbolic gestures and as reflections of the state's unique relationship with national politics. Therefore, this movement offers a contemporary lens to understand how political and cultural forces continue to shape Texas's legislative and symbolic expressions of identity.

Section 4. Methodology

The purpose of this case study was to explore how Texas's traditionalistic values have shaped public expressions of state identity, with a focus on the Texas Pledge of Allegiance as a primary example. This qualitative case study investigated the Texas Pledge's evolution as an indicator of broader cultural and political shifts and drew comparisons with other state aspects influenced by similar values.

I chose this qualitative case study to address the following research questions; 1) How has the evolution of the Texas Pledge reflected the influence of Texas's traditionalistic values? And 2) In what ways do other Texas-specific symbols, policies, or cultural norms reflect similar changes, motivated by traditional values? My study aimed to analyze how Texas's commitment to traditionalism has influenced public symbols, legislation, and state identity. By focusing on the Pledge and comparing it with other Texas-specific aspects, this approach allowed for a nuanced understanding of how traditional values shape the cultural and political landscape.

As the researcher, I am aware that my interest in Texas's unique identity may influence my analysis. I will ensure that my interpretations remain unbiased and grounded in historical evidence. Data will be collected through analysis of historical records, legislative documents, news articles, and public commentary on the Texas Pledge, alongside similar sources on other Texas state elements influenced by traditional values. Potential limitations include the restricted availability of recent scholarly sources on the Pledge itself, which will require broadening the scope to incorporate related Texas symbols and policies.

To ensure trustworthiness, I will maintain an audit trail of all sources and records used, acknowledge my own biases, and create a transparent documentation process. By maintaining a consistent data audit trail and engaging in reflexivity, I aim to ensure the study's findings are reliable and unbiased.

Section 5. Data and Result

To understand how these deep-rooted principles manifested in our modern-day policy and public life, this case study explored four areas that reflected Texas' ongoing commitment to traditionalism. These areas were selected because they are prominently discussed and debated within the state, and ample sources were available to support the analysis. The chosen areas were educational policies with book bans and censorship, abortion legislation with the Texas Heartbeat Act (S.B. No. 8), and the aftermath of the overturned *Roe v Wade* court case (410 U.S. 113, 1973) Texas' conservative principles of individual freedom with gun rights (U.S. Const. amend. XIX), and Texas' religious bill on displaying the Ten Commandments in public schools. Each of these topics not only exemplifies the traditionalistic political culture of Texas but also illustrates how state-specific values continue to influence contemporary legislation and public life.

The rise in book bans across Texas schools exemplifies the state's traditionalistic values and concerns about preserving cultural norms and protecting children from content that was deemed inappropriate. In 2023, a new Texas law that aimed at restricting what books students could access in school libraries came into effect, leading to an increase in local book bans across the state (Schwartz, 2024). This effort reflects a broader conservative agenda to control educational content and reinforce traditional norms. In districts like Katy, school officials spent \$93,000 on new books, only to store them for review, resulting in the ban of 14 titles. This includes well-known books by Dr. Seuss and Judy Blume, along with "No, David!" This is a children's book that has won awards and shows a naughty cartoon character who, at one moment, jumps out of a bathtub, showing a cartoon backside. (Schwartz, 2024). These actions raise questions about what was considered unacceptable by the Texas government and the content norms that they are trying to establish. These policies primarily affect students, limiting their access to diverse literature and critical thinking opportunities. Educators face increased scrutiny and potential consequences for using certain materials. Additionally, LGBTQ+ students and minority groups are disproportionately impacted, as literature representing their experiences is removed that was deemed "sexually explicit" or inappropriate.

These measures underscore a clear alignment with the state's traditionalistic political culture, which often seeks to align public education with conservative values and shield students from material deemed inappropriate. Such actions have had a ripple effect, creating what Kasey Meehan, director of the Freedom to Read program at PEN America, describes as a "chilling effect" on the availability of literature (Schwartz, 2024). This increase in book challenges and removals not only shapes the educational landscape but reflects broader cultural and political

dynamics in Texas, demonstrating how deeply ingrained traditional values influence public policy and expressions of state identity.

While the rise in book bans shows Texas's commitment to shaping educational content in line with traditional values, the state's approach to reproductive rights further exemplifies how deeply these conservative principles influence broader social policies. Abortion legislation in Texas, highlighted by the Texas Heartbeat Act (S.B. No. 8), and the aftermath of the *Roe v. Wade* reversal (410 U.S. 113, 1973), serves as a clear representation of the state's adherence to traditionalistic values and the influence of religious conservatism in shaping public policy. The Texas Heartbeat Act, implemented in 2021, bans abortions once cardiac activity is detected. It is typically around six weeks into pregnancy, which is often before many individuals realize they are pregnant, although medical experts have noted that at six weeks, the "heartbeat" is merely electrical impulses rather than evidence of a developed heart (Irvine, 2021). Despite the medical clarifications, the term "heartbeat" has been a powerful rhetorical tool for rallying support and reinforcing conservative views on what is considered to be a living being at the earliest stage. The law's unique enforcement mechanism, which allows private citizens to sue anyone who performs or aids an abortion, exemplifies Texas's commitment to intertwining community action with state policy. This mechanism not only empowers citizens but also shifts the burden of enforcement away from the state, symbolizing a broader cultural resistance to federal oversight (Irvine, 2021). After the Supreme Court's *Dobbs v. Jackson Women's Health Organization* decision in 2022 overturned *Roe v. Wade*, Texas enacted a "trigger law" banning abortion from fertilization, except to save the mother's life or prevent severe harm (Aldridge, 2024). After the *Dobbs v. Jackson* case, the stricter laws have created significant uncertainty for patients and providers. Doctors risk severe penalties for unauthorized procedures, including license loss and

lengthy prison sentences of up to life in imprisonment depending on the actions of the abortions. This reinforced Texas's commitment to embedding religious and traditional principles in its policies. The Texas Heartbeat Act and subsequent legislative actions illustrate the state's deep-rooted traditionalism, embedding conservative Christian values into public policy. Supporters, including state leaders and anti-abortion groups, celebrate these laws as victories for life and moral responsibility. However, some argue that they compromise women's healthcare, disproportionately affect marginalized communities, and limit individual autonomy.

But then again, moving away from the highly restrictive abortion laws that depict Texas's religious and moral rules, the state's attitude toward gun rights further underlines its focus on individual liberties and self-reliance. This emphasis parallels the Texas Pledge of Allegiance, which itself is an expression of state pride and independence, values that are similarly showcased in the state's gun policies. The enactment of permit-less carry laws in 2021 allowing residents to carry handguns without a license if they are legally eligible to possess a firearm further underscores Texas's commitment to protecting individual rights. This legislative move highlights Texas's resistance to what it perceives as federal overreach and regulatory imposition, maintaining the state's longstanding tradition of minimal government interference (Convington, 2022). Gun ownership in Texas has a complex relationship with public safety and societal impacts. While the state advocates these freedoms, the aftermath of events like the 2022 Uvalde school shooting demonstrates a broader societal response that underscores Texans' belief in self-reliance. Following such tragedies, background checks for firearm purchases in Texas spiked by 17%, reflecting a cultural instinct to safeguard oneself rather than seek broader regulatory measures (Covington, 2022). This surge reflects the deeply seated perception that personal protection is a right to be safeguarded, representing the Pledge's commitment to independence

and resilience. While firearm freedoms are seen as essential to individual rights, they come with significant social implications. Gun violence data reveal that firearm-related deaths disproportionately affect different demographic groups, with Black Texans more likely to experience gun homicides in urban areas, while firearm suicides are more prevalent among White Texans in rural regions (Covington, 2022). This reflects the Pledge's deeper meaning of "*one state under God, one and indivisible*", portraying unity but revealing the multifaceted challenges tied to upholding such freedoms. Texas's commitment to individual rights, as expressed through its gun policies, mirrors the spirit of its Pledge, asserting an identity rooted in personal liberty and distinct from national norms. This alignment showcases how deeply traditionalistic values shape not just symbolic expressions but tangible legislative actions that define Texas's unique character.

Following Texas's emphasis on individual freedoms and its culturally ingrained gun rights, the state's recent legislation on religious displays in public schools reflects another dimension of its traditionalistic values. Senate Bill 1515, passed in 2023, mandates that public schools should display the Ten Commandments in every classroom (Lopez, 2023). This legislation is part of a broader effort to reinforce religious principles within public institutions, showcasing how deeply these values are embedded in Texas's approach to policy and governance. The introduction of this bill by Senator Phil King aligns with Texas's historical narrative of independence and moral conservatism.

Much like the Texas Pledge of Allegiance, which underscores the state's distinct identity and its cultural emphasis on faith through the phrase "*one state under God*," the mandate to display the Ten Commandments symbolizes a reassertion of religious influence as a core aspect of Texas identity. Phil King highlighted that integrating religious elements into schools would

remind students of the “fundamental foundation of America” and bolster cultural and moral teachings in line with traditional values (Lopez, 2023). However, the mandate has sparked significant debate. Critics, such as John Litzler from the Texas Baptist Christian Life Commission, have raised concerns about the use of taxpayer money to purchase religious texts and the potential infringement on parental rights (Lopez, 2023). They argue that religious discussions should remain within the family’s home, not dictated by public educational institutions. This tension echoes broader concerns about the separation of church and state, highlighting how the policy may challenge the inclusive and diverse environment that public schools aim to foster. The legislative move to reintroduce religious displays in schools resonates with the broader themes in the Texas Pledge, showcasing a distinct identity that intertwines state pride, religious values, and a commitment to tradition. Texas’s recent religious bills, like the mandate to display the Ten Commandments, continue to showcase how the state integrates traditionalistic and religious values into public life. This legislative stance not only highlights the influence of religious conservatism but also serves as an extension of the principles symbolized by the Texas Pledge, reinforcing the state’s unique approach to governance and identity.

Section 6. Social Implications

Given the limited direct sources on the Texas Pledge itself, this paper expanded its scope to explore how the Pledge serves as a focal point for understanding the broader cultural and political issues in Texas. By examining policies ranging from educational restrictions to religious mandates, this study traces a consistent pattern where traditional values inform state legislation and public identity. The Pledge, with its declaration of unity under God, serves as a symbolic representation of Texas’s ideological commitment, highlighting how such values are manifested in political actions and cultural expressions. This broader scope allows for a deeper

understanding of how the Pledge, though a symbolic statement, is intricately tied to the ongoing evolution of Texas's state identity and its political landscape.

The exploration of how Texas's traditionalistic values shape public expressions of state identity through the Texas Pledge and various legislative actions reveals deep-rooted cultural and political priorities. The Texas Pledge, with its declaration of "*one state under God*," embodies the state's commitment to aligning public life with traditional values. This commitment is mirrored in educational policies, abortion legislation, gun rights, and religious mandates, showcasing a state's intent on preserving its unique identity.

The implications of these policies extend beyond symbolic expressions and into societal impacts. The alignment of state policies with traditional values often reinforces social divisions, influencing access to resources, freedom of expression, and public safety. For example, book bans and censorship can limit educational diversity, impacting critical thinking and representation for marginalized groups. Similarly, stringent abortion laws reflect religious conservatism but can compromise healthcare access, especially with pregnant people. The prioritization of gun rights highlights an insistence on individual freedoms, yet it brings complex public health challenges that disproportionately affect different demographics. Finally, the mandated display of the Ten Commandments in schools underscores an approach to governance that intertwines religious beliefs with public policy, sparking debates on constitutional freedoms and the separation of church and state.

These findings suggest that Texas's legislative framework may continue to evolve in ways that reinforce its cultural distinctiveness. Future research should consider the long-term effects of such policies on Texas's demographic landscape, public trust, and the state's relationship with national governance. Understanding these implications can provide insights

into how traditionalistic values influence legislative priorities and their resonance with broader political movements.

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